

10, Why Did Classical Empires Emerge So Early in Iran and India?

The widespread existence of massive tribes and grassroots **communities** (社群) is undeniably a detrimental factor for **feudalization** (封建化). Yet, bizarrely enough, their pervasive existence might have enabled **classical empires** (古典帝国) to emerge much earlier, even though the standard morphology of a **classical empire** would not appear until much later.

If we observe Iran and India, this paradox immediately surfaces before our eyes. From the birth of the Achaemenid Dynasty (阿契美尼德王朝) to Iran's typical **late-classical states** (*Sasanian Persia, which will be discussed shortly*), there is a staggering gap of 11 centuries! Similarly, from the establishment of the Maurya Dynasty (孔雀王朝) to the collapse of the Gupta Dynasty (笈多王朝), the span exceeds 800 years! (*Though it should be noted that before the Maurya Dynasty was established, the Kingdom of Magadha had already been expanding for two centuries, having achieved hegemony over Northern India during the preceding Nanda Dynasty [难陀王朝]*).

When the Achaemenid and Maurya dynasties first emerged, the process of **feudalization** had not yet commenced; even the private ownership of land was insufficiently developed.

The rationale sustaining the premature existence of these **early classical empires** has been hypothesized previously regarding centralized power: namely, **the exploitation of cities and commerce**. Although the surviving historical materials from that era are exceedingly scarce today, the limited content we possess undeniably corroborates this point.

The Maurya Dynasty attached monumental importance to the control of cities, establishing complex municipal systems for urban management and relying primarily on provincial capitals to project control over local regions. This regime forged a relatively sophisticated coinage system; various officially sanctioned coins were utilized for commerce, and trade with the external world was massively expanded. The Achaemenid Dynasty inherited the highly developed pre-existing trade networks of the Near East and pioneered a bimetallic (gold and silver) currency system.

Cultural characteristics laterally prove the paramount importance of commerce in the First Persian Empire. For instance, within the belief system of the ancient Persians, lying was deemed an atrociously extreme evil. In his inscriptions, Darius I (大流士一世) repeatedly emphasized that he never lied and severely punished enemies who did. Herodotus noted: *The Persians consider lying to be the most disgraceful act in the world, followed by owing debt, because a man in debt is inevitably bound to tell lies.*

This specific record allows people to deduce the true underlying reason why Persians harbored such a visceral hatred for lying: **Commerce occupied an absolutely foundational position within their entire society**. In ancient societies, logistics and transportation fundamentally could not be compared to the present. If a merchant acted dishonestly—such as trading heavily degraded, poor-quality goods—it was exceptionally difficult for the victim to defend their rights. After all, many trading partners might only meet once and never have the opportunity to cross paths again in their lifetimes! (*Mesopotamia has literally unearthed such clay tablets complaining about the dishonest commercial practices of partners—specifically the infamous Ea-nāsir copper complaint—which later even became a popular internet meme*).

If commercial behavior plays a paramount role in a society, and widespread dishonesty possesses the potential to shatter commercial networks, then it is not the least bit surprising that the society's ideology would hyper-emphasize the absolute sinfulness of lying.

The reasons why these empires could be established militarily can be attributed to superior geopolitical environments, the emergence of **Charismatic leaders** (卡里斯玛式领袖), and military innovations (*such as the utilization of Median cavalry by the Persians*).

This leaves only one lingering question: **How did these empires execute their rule over local territories?**

I contend the answer lies here: within the expansive territories of the Persian and Magadhan empires, tribes and **communities** still existed in massive abundance, constituting the absolute bedrock for local autonomy.

Whether under the Achaemenid Dynasty or the Maurya Dynasty, in remote regions far removed from the empire's core strongholds, local rulers nominally submitted to the empire but continued to govern their jurisdictions entirely according to their traditional methods. Their actual obligations to the imperial court were exceedingly limited.

The imperial rulers exhibited tolerance toward local religions and cultures, explicitly permitting local autonomy. **Rather than attributing this to the personal morality or ideology of the rulers, it is vastly more accurate to say that co-opting local tribes and communities into the state's political apparatus—strictly according to their original governance models—was the foundational bedrock upon which the empire's very existence was predicated.**

This was dictated by the fact that these "**early classical empires**" had not yet evolved into a genuine classical era. The aristocrats, priests, and slaveowners who held dominant status in the **early states** (早期国家) had not yet decayed; **feudal** relations of production had not yet emerged; and there was a severe deficit of "non-productive bureaucrats" (脱产官僚) required for the state to execute direct governance over local regions. **Had there not been a colossal multitude of tribes and communities capable of governing themselves, the empire would have been utterly paralyzed and incapable of ruling.**

We note that a century prior to the rise of Persia, the Neo-Assyrian Empire (新亚述帝国) had already occupied vast swathes of the Near East through brutal military conquest. However, the Assyrian rulers absolutely did not appease the conquered regions like Cyrus the Great (居鲁士) later did, nor did they integrate the pre-existing local governance structures into their empire. On the contrary, the Assyrian rulers forcibly relocated the populations of conquered regions on a massive scale, deliberately obliterating local governance structures.

The ultimate consequence of this strategy was that once the Assyrian conquests reached their absolute zenith, the empire collapsed almost instantaneously upon turning on its heel (旋踵而亡).

Here, we observe a distinct characteristic on the eve of China's classical unification. Because China is a **primary civilization** (原生文明) with an excessively protracted history, the **early states** in the North had already been locked in mutual warfare and slaughter for a monumentally long time.

As mentioned previously, a glaring distinction of China during **The Great Expansion** (大扩张) was the pre-existence of the Western Zhou regime orchestrating this very process. In other words, when

the Great Expansion commenced, a dominant state already reigned over the Yellow River basin. Furthermore, across Northern China (*and we can also include the regions between the Yangtze and Huai rivers / 江淮之间*), there existed absolutely no impassable geographical barriers partitioning this territory of over a million square kilometers! Early Chinese civilization had already incubated a massive population. (*Though population figures from that era are undeniably difficult to verify, I have adopted a relatively compromised estimate: the population within the Western Zhou's domain basically equaled the combined populations of the Fertile Crescent and Egypt at the time, and likely exceeded it slightly as the Zhou expanded*).

The aforementioned factors forged a fascinating historical reality: in other regions, **The Great Expansion** generally manifested as a pioneering model driven by ethnic groups who had already mastered the utilization of iron tools. **In China, however, iron tools only participated in the latter half of the Great Expansion!** Throughout the entirety of the Western Zhou period, Huaxia conquerors (华夏族) were steadily carving out new colonial strongholds utilizing merely *bronze* tools.

This, to a significant extent, demonstrates that as the **only primary civilization** participating in **the Great Expansion**, China was alarmingly, overwhelmingly "over-mature" (过于成熟了) in its state morphology and social structure compared to all other competitors on the track.

On the eve of the Chinese Empire's unification, the ubiquitous tribes and **communities** (社群) characteristic of **early states** had already been utterly pulverized and annihilated in the crucible of ceaseless, increasingly high-intensity warfare! Consequently, they fundamentally possessed no capacity to participate in the construction of state politics as autonomous local forces.

During the Warring States period (战国时期), the various vassal states began implementing the *Fengjun* system (封君制 / enfeoffment of lords). (*Here, "enfeoffed lords" refers to aristocrats possessing noble titles and fiefs, acting as vassals to the monarch*). However, this status quo was notoriously unstable. In the fifty years preceding Qin's unification, rebellions by enfeoffed lords within the Qin state had become crippling severe, and the situation in other vassal states was equally bleak. Enfeoffed lords of immense prestige could easily overshadow their kings—either monopolizing the state's administrative prerogatives (like Lord Chunshen / 春申君) or essentially operating quasi-independent kingdoms (like Lord Mengchang / 孟尝君). Monarchs harbored profound insecurity when facing these formidable ministers (强臣), and the number of enfeoffed lords who managed to die a natural, peaceful death was vanishingly small. Evidently, this political model was chronically unstable.

When the Qin Dynasty (秦朝) first unified China, it was perhaps precisely out of profound anxiety regarding this *Fengjun* system that it stubbornly insisted on administrating the entire realm exclusively through the Commandery and County system (郡县制 / *Junxian* system). However, the sheer number of available state officials absolutely could not support the voracious demands of such a colossal bureaucratic political machine; the intense hostility the conquered regions harbored toward the Qin rulers only catastrophically exacerbated this vulnerability.

The early Han Dynasty (汉朝初年) inherited this exact tension from the Warring States period. Although the absolute majority of the vassal kingdoms (诸侯王国) were ruled by imperial relatives of the Han house, the central court in Chang'an treated these kingdoms as existential hypothetical

enemies for half a century! The court strictly prohibited population flows into the vassal kingdoms and deployed defensive military arrangements against them.

Therefore, we can assert that in China, several centuries *before* a distinct class succession could generate a sufficient volume of **non-productive bureaucrats** (脱产官僚), the tribes and **communities** capable of sustaining local autonomy had already withered and died! (*While it is impossible to estimate the exact timeline, they had undeniably vanished by the time the Warring States universally launched their legalist reforms*).

A glaring "window period" (空窗期 / political vacuum) emerged precisely in this gap.

Consequently, when China crossed the threshold into its classical era, its social structure was phenomenally simpler than those of Iran and India. The empire's **"internal frontiers"** (内部边疆) had essentially been completely eradicated. China never witnessed the emergence of an **"early classical empire"**—one that heavily relied on cities and commercial circulation, while leaning on tribes and **communities** for autonomous local governance.

The entire society was fundamentally stripped of any buffer zones (缺乏缓冲); it functioned like a colossal yet pathologically hypersensitive machine.

Coupled with the fact that the volume of surviving ancient literature in China is indeed astronomically larger than in other regions, the transitional characteristics of the **classical empire** became glaringly magnified, and the bureaucratic system of China's classical era proved to be unprecedentedly formidable and draconian.

10，为什么伊朗和印度的古典帝国诞生这么早

大量部族，基层社群（**Communities**）的存在对于封建化是一个不利的因素，但是看起来非常诡异的是，它们的广泛存在可能使古典帝国更早出现，尽管一般形式的古典帝国还要晚很久。如果观察伊朗和印度这个问题就浮现在人们眼前，从阿契美尼德诞生到伊朗的典型古典帝国相隔 11 个世纪（萨珊波斯马上就会讨论），从孔雀王朝（不过孔雀王朝建立之前摩揭陀国已经扩张了两个世纪，在上一个王朝难陀王朝（Nanda）统治时就已经取得了北印度的霸权）建立到笈多王朝灭亡相隔也超过了 800 年，在阿契美尼德王朝和孔雀王朝出现的时候，封建化的进程还未开始，甚至土地私有制都没有充分发展。支撑这些古典帝国过早存在的原因之前已经推测过中央权力的方面，也就是对城市和商业的利用。虽然那个年代的资料留存到今天的已经十分稀少，不过有限的内容还是证明了这一点。孔雀王朝非常重视对城市的控制，为管理城市建立了复杂的市政系统，对于地方的控制主要依托省份首府。这个政权建立了比较完善的货币铸造系统，各类在官方许可下铸造的货币被用于商业，与外部世界的贸易也扩大了。阿契美尼德王朝继承了近东地区原本就发达的贸易网络，开创了金银双金属货币系统。文化上的特征从侧面证明了商业在波斯第一帝国的重要性，例如，在当年波斯人的信仰中谎言是极端的恶行，大流士一世在铭文中反复强调自己不会说谎并且惩罚了说谎的敌人。希罗多德指出：波斯人认为，世界上最可耻的是说谎，其次是欠债，因为欠债的人注定会说谎。这条记载可以让人们推想出波斯人对于说谎如此痛恨的原因，那就是商业在整个社会中占据了极其重要的地位。在古代社会，物流交通远不能跟现在相比，一旦商人不诚实做出交易了品质低劣的货物这样的行为，受害者很难维护自己的权利，毕竟很多贸易伙伴见一次这辈子也都未必有机会了。（美索不达米亚就出土了这样控诉合作者商业不诚信行为的泥板，后来还在互联网上流行起来）如果商业行为在一个社会中扮演了极其重要的位置，普遍不诚信的行为可能会破坏商业网络，那么社会意识形态高度强调说谎的罪恶就毫不令人奇怪了。

帝国在军事得以建立的原因可以解释为优越的地缘环境，卡里斯玛式领袖的出现，以及军事上的革新（例如波斯米底的骑兵使用）。那么就只剩下一个问题，这些帝国在地方的统治如何进行？我认为答案在于，在波斯帝国和摩揭陀帝国的统治范围内，部族和社群仍然大量存在，构成了地方自治的基础。无论是阿契美尼德王朝还是孔雀王朝，在远离帝国统治据点的偏远地方，当地统治者虽然在形式上服从于帝国，但是依然按照原有的方式统治自己的辖地，对于朝廷负有的义务是非常有限的。帝国的统治者对于地方的宗教和文化表现宽容，允许地方进行自治，这与其说是统治者个人的思想道德所决定的，不如说将地方的部族和社群按照他们原本的治理模式纳入国家政治中来是帝国得以存在的基石。这是因为“早期古典帝国”并没有发展到真正的古典时期，早期国家中具有统治地位的贵族、祭司、奴隶主还未衰落，封建生产关系也没有出现，缺少足够的脱产官僚以使国家可以对于地方进行直接的治理。假如没有数目庞大的有能力自治的部族和社群，帝国同样没办法进行统治。我们注意到在波斯兴起之前一个世纪，新亚述帝国就已经通过军事征伐占领了近东的广大地区，但是亚述统治者并没有像后来的居鲁士一样安抚被征服的地方，把当地旧有的治理结构纳入帝国当中。与之相反，亚述统治者甚至大规模强制迁徙被征服地区的居民，有意破坏被征服地方的治理结构。这样做的最终结果是，亚述人的征服达到极点之后几乎旋踵而亡。

在这里我们看到了中国古典统一前夕的一个特点，中国作为一个原生文明历史过于漫长，北方各早期国家之间互相攻伐的时间已经很久。之前已经提到，中国在大扩张时期的一个显著不同是，曾经存在过一个西周政权领导这一进程，换言之大扩张开始的时候黄河流域已经存在占统治地位的国家。中国北方（也可以再把江淮之间算上）并不存在难以进行开发的区域隔断这上百万平方公里的国土，早期中华文明已经孕育了大量的人口（不过那个年代的人口确实难以考据，我采取了比较折中的数据，结果是西周统治区的人口基本等于同期新月沃土加埃及的人口，随着周朝扩张可能还会略多）。以上因素造成了一个有趣的事实，大扩张在其他地区一般都以掌握了铁器使用的族群进行开拓的模式出现，但是在中国，铁器其实只参与了大扩张的后半段。在整个西周时期，华夏族的征服者就在稳步地用青铜工具开拓新的殖民据点，这就在一定程度上说明作为唯一参与大扩张的原生文明，中国和赛道上的其他选手相比在国家形态、社会形态上过于成熟了。

在中华帝国统一的前夕，早期国家中普遍的部族和社群已经在经年累月并且烈度越来越大的战争中毁灭，没办法在作为地方性的自治力量参与到国家政治的构建中。战国时期诸侯国开始实施封君制（这里的封君指的是有爵位和封地的贵族，属于国君的封臣），但是这种状态非常不稳定。秦国在统一前的 50 年间封君叛乱已经变得十分严重，其他诸侯国也不乐观，有名望的封君声势压倒了国王，或者辅国特权（春申君），或者近似于独立王国（孟尝君）。君主在面对这些强臣的时候感到不安全，封君能够善终的也是少数，显然这种政治模式并不稳定。秦朝在初次统一中国时或许就是出于对封君制的忧虑，坚持采取全部以郡县治理的方式，不过官吏的数量并不支持如此庞大的官僚政治的需要，被征服地区对秦统治者的敌视加剧了这一点。汉朝初年延续了战国以来的紧张感，虽然诸侯王国绝大多数都是汉室宗亲，但是长安朝廷在半个世纪里却把诸侯王国视为假想敌，严禁人口流入诸侯王国，并且做出防范性的军事布置。所以我们可以说在中国，明显的阶级交替产生足够的脱产官僚之前几个世纪，能够维持地方自治的部族和社群就已经衰亡了（虽然没法估计具体时间，不过战国诸侯国普遍开始变法的时候肯定就没了），这之间出现了一个空窗期。因此中国在进入古典时期的时候社会结构要比伊朗和印度简单得多，帝国的“内部边疆”已经被基本消灭，没有出现高度依赖城市和流通的，在地方依靠部族和社群自行治理的早期古典帝国。整个社会缺乏缓冲，像是一台庞大而又过于灵敏的机器，再加上中国留存下来的古代文献数目相对于其他地区确实多，因此古典帝国作为过渡时期的特征就会变得非常明显，古典时期的官僚制度也会更强大。